

The Crooked Forest

Location Western Pomerania, Poland

This is a bizarre-looking group of 400 pine trees that are bent at a 90-degree angle close to the ground and have subsequently readjusted to grow vertically again. Even stranger, the trees are surrounded by a forest of normal, upright trees. Several theories have been advanced to explain the phenomenon, but the most likely one is that the farmers who planted the trees in the 1930s were responsible. They may have

wanted trees with curved trunks to use for shipbuilding or the manufacture of furniture.

Hainich National Park

Location Thuringia, central Germany

This national park contains part of the largest continuous area of deciduous forest in Germany, Hainich Forest, which is dominated by European beech. The park is being managed with the intention of allowing the forest, which was formerly used for military training, to return to

its natural state. In spring, before the thick canopy closes, an understory includes masses of wild garlic. Later, 16 species of orchid grow here, which provide a habitat for wildcats, bats, woodpeckers, and thousands of species of invertebrates.

The Black Forest

Location Baden-Württemberg, southwest Germany

This large upland area is called the Black Forest because the spruce trees here grow so close together that parts of it are very dark. The area is an uplifted fault

block (horst) of sandstone, gneiss, and granite, which is bounded by the Rhine River to the south and west. The forest is roughly 100 miles (160 km) by 40 miles (60 km). The original cover of mixed forest was largely cleared in the 19th century to be replaced by spruce monoculture for forestry, but recent years have seen an increase in deciduous tree cover once more. Spruce and silver fir mingle with stands of beech in the hills and valleys of the forest. Germany's two largest nature parks are in the Black Forest, and there is also a national park.

▼ PINE TREES IN THE CROOKED FOREST

